

Hyper-Logistics: Weaponized Economics

In *Zero Sum*, the economy is the deadliest enemy in the game. Combat shouldn't just drain hit points; it should bankrupt you. Logistics are not a background mechanic—they are the primary driver of horror.

1. Generational Debt (The Guarantor Act)

Characters do not start at zero; they start with crippling debt (housing, medical, oxygen taxes). **Debt is a core stat.** - **The Transfer:** If a character dies or their Trauma maxes out, they aren't simply removed from the game. Due to the "Guarantor Act," their negative balance is legally transferred to their designated emergency contact. - **Next-of-Kin:** The player's *newly rolled character* is this emergency contact. You inherit your predecessor's financial ruin, ensuring that death offers no escape from the Board's ledgers.

2. Algorithmic Surge Pricing

Corporate medical dispensers and ammo kiosks are monitored by advanced biometrics. - **Surge Mechanic:** If a player is bleeding out and stumbles to a kiosk, the machine's biometric sensors detect their elevated heart rate, adrenaline, and desperation. The algorithm automatically triggers "Surge Pricing," raising the cost of bandages, coagulants, and stims by up to 400% in real-time. Survival is a luxury priced for the desperate.

3. DRM & Subscription Gear

You do not own your firearm or your water purifier; you license them. - **Digital Rights Management:** Weapons feature corporate DRM. If you miss a subscription payment, or if you attempt to shoot a Board executive (violating the Terms of Service), the gun's smart-trigger "bricks" itself via Bluetooth. - **Jailbreaking:** "Jailbreaking" gear becomes a mandatory, high-risk survival skill.

Firing a jailbroken weapon carries a risk of catastrophic malfunction, but it is the only way to ensure the Board cannot remotely disarm you.

4. The Gig-Economy of Violence

There are no “quest givers” in the traditional sense. Jobs are dispensed via mandatory, unfeeling algorithmic apps (e.g., *Taskr* or *Hustl*). - **Blind Bidding:** Players must blindly bid on contracts against other desperate crews. - **The Margin:** If they bid too low to secure the job, the payout won’t even cover the cost of the ammo and calories expended to complete it. Players are forced to constantly calculate the ROI (Return on Investment) of pulling the trigger.